

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

25 April 2018

To the Delegates to the Twelfth International Bahá'í Convention

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

It is with great joy and anticipation, more particularly during this period of special potency, that we extend to you a most loving welcome to the Holy Land on the occasion of the Twelfth International Bahá'í Convention. The convocation of delegates from an anticipated 166 countries—the highest number of National Spiritual Assemblies to be represented at an International Convention—is a cause for celebration; it also brings to mind the presence in spirit of delegates from other countries, whose involvement, owing to certain circumstances, is confined to voting through postal ballot. With profound gratitude to Bahá'u'lláh, we acknowledge the historic participation of representatives from a number of Arab countries. The National Spiritual Assembly of Egypt, as a result of restrictions and government policies in that country, was dissolved in 1960, prior to the election of the first Universal House of Justice; that National Assembly, initially formed during the early years of Shoghi Effendi's ministry, was finally re-established at Riḍván 2014. Also, although they have participated in past elections by post, we welcome for the very first time delegates from the National Spiritual Assemblies of Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait, Morocco, Tunisia, and the United Arab Emirates. Beyond this, we are most happy to note the presence of members of the National Spiritual Assemblies of Liberia and Mozambique, which were reformed within the past five years.

As you prepare for the sacred duty of electing the members of the Universal House of Justice, you are lovingly invited to visit the Holy Shrines. Mindful of 'Abdu'l-Bahá's assurance that attaining the Most Holy Threshold is akin to attaining the very presence of the Blessed Beauty, let your whole being be refreshed with the perfume of divine fragrance. With sanctified spirits and in a rarefied atmosphere of purity and detachment, you will then gather on the first morning of the Convention to discharge, in a manner far, far removed from the prevailing standards of elections in the world, your weighty responsibility.

Your participation, as the chosen representatives of the Bahá'í world, in the consultative sessions of the Convention offers a precious opportunity to contemplate together, in the light of experience, the vital issues facing the Cause as everywhere individuals, institutions, and communities strive and grow in capacity to serve humanity—a humanity caught up in a bewildering maelstrom. The exigencies of the present stage of the Divine Plan will be at the heart of these deliberations, as indicated by the themes designated for each of the various sessions. You may, of course, after due reflection, bring forward additional matters that you feel are essential to the progress and well-being of the Faith.

A specially commissioned film entitled *A Widening Embrace*—presenting a synthesis of efforts at the grassroots to document learning about growth in a range of diverse settings—will be screened on the second day of the Convention. The film provides vivid glimpses of the society-building power of Bahá'u'lláh's Revelation that is becoming manifest as believers across the planet labour with vision, earnestness, and devotion.

During your stay, you will no doubt find time to visit and enjoy the new Pilgrim Reception Centre in Haifa, recently acquired and refurbished to host growing numbers of eagerly anticipated pilgrims from the communities you serve. The beloved Guardian had himself hoped to acquire this property, so close to the hallowed precincts of the Shrine of the Báb, for the Faith.

These precious days spent in prayer and contemplation within the Sacred Shrines and Holy Places during this Rīḍván season, together with your participation in the International Convention, will surely inspire your souls and prepare you for the vital undertakings awaiting you in the field of action. Returning to your communities as beacons of light, may your renewed consecration, heightened consciousness, and increased resolve sustain you throughout these swiftly passing, final years of the first century of the Formative Age.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]